

TASK 5 CYBERCRIMES AND AWARENESS

Case Study: UPI Fraud in India

UPI fraud has emerged as one of the fastest-growing cybercrimes in India, targeting millions of everyday smartphone users. With the explosive rise of digital payments through apps like **PhonePe**, **Google Pay**, and **Paytm**, fraudsters have found clever ways to exploit unsuspecting victims.

How It Happens: A typical UPI fraud begins with a fraudster posing as a bank official, customer support agent, or even a known contact. They reach out via **phone call, SMS, or WhatsApp**, claiming there is an issue with the victim's account, **KYC verification**, or a pending payment. The victim is then persuaded to share their **UPI PIN, OTP, or click on a malicious link**. In many cases, fraudsters send a "**collect request**" — making the victim believe they are *receiving* money, when in reality they are *approving a payment* from their own account.

Who Is Targeted: Fraudsters primarily target first-time UPI users, senior citizens unfamiliar with digital

transactions, **small business owners, online shoppers, and people selling items on platforms like OLX** or Facebook Marketplace. Anyone who receives an unexpected call offering cashback, refunds, or lottery winnings is also at high risk.

The consequences can be devastating — victims lose hard-earned savings within seconds, and recovery is often difficult.